Shambhuji was under the wicked influence of his family priest Kavi Kalash. Kavi Kalash was the caretaker of Shambhuji in Varanasi during Shivaji's flight from Agra. He later brought Shambhuji safely to Raigarh. His dominance in the Court became absolute in course of time, as Shambhuji looked to his advice for everything. Kavi Kalash was a distinguished scholar and poet. But he was a practitioner of witchcraft. So the orthodox Hindus in the court had developed a deep hatred for him. When Shambhuji was captured by the Mughal army, he was found to be in the company of Kavi Kalash. So both of them were subjected to all forms of torture and then executed by the orders of Aurangzeb.

Shahu Maharaja

Shivaji's grandson Shahu means honest, originally a name given by Aurangzeb to contrast his character with that of Shivaji) ruled from 1708 to 1749. During the first half of the eighteenth century, consolidation of royal power was achieved through conferment of royal entitlements upon those who served Shahu.



Shahu Maharaja

During Shahu's 40-year reign there was increase in the territory under the Maratha control, from which tribute was regularly extracted. More centralised and strong state structure also began to take shape. Every household, including that of landed household, profited from state employment.

Peshwas

Balaji Vishwanath (1713–1720) began his career as a small revenue official and became Peshwa in 1713. Much against the advice from his close circles, Shahu appointed 20-year-old Viswanath's eldest son Bajirao to occupy the office of Peshwa.



Balaji Vishwanath

Bajirao (1720–1740)

Bajirao decided to launch a major Maratha onslaught against the Mughals and the Nizam of Hyderabad. He assumed the powers of the commander-in-chief. He was wise in his choice of commanders for these campaigns. Instead of relying on the traditional elite group, namely Deshmukhs, he gave commands to the Gaikwad,

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